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The Nationalisation of Subnational Elections in Polarised Spain:

The May 2023 Regional and Local Elections

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Abstract

This article examines the May 2023 regional and local elections in Spain. The vote confirmed the territorial retrenchment of the left-leaning national government coalition members (PSOE and UP) and sparked a call for snap general elections. The outcome of these sub-national elections was notably shaped by the divergent trajectories of the newer parties (Cs, UP, and Vox), as well as by the considerable increase in the support of the main opposition party (PP). This report shows how the existing high levels of political polarisation contributed to nationalising the campaign and electoral results in May 2023.

Keywords: subnational elections; polarisation; negative campaigning; nationalisation; radical parties; coalition governments.

Introduction

On May 28th, 2023, Spain conducted regional and local elections amidst exceptional political turbulence. As the highly eventful and contested term of the first national coalition government approached its end,¹ the main state-wide opposition parties (Partido Popular [Popular Party – PP, conservative], Vox [Voice, radical right], and Ciudadanos [Citizens – Cs, liberal]) framed the concurrent vote in 8,131 municipalities, 12 Autonomous Communities, and 2 Autonomous Cities² as a referendum on the policies and legislative alliances of the national coalition government members (Lamet & Mondelo 2023). The national coalition partners faced the election after years of wear and tear, and both the Socialist Party (Partido Socialista Obrero Español [Spanish Socialist Worker Party-PSOE, social democratic]) and Unidas Podemos (United We Can [UP, radical left]) adopted a hybrid strategy (Cabeza, Gómez & Alonso 2017), balancing between a territorialised and a nationalised stance due to the mixed economic performance of the national government and the proximity of general elections.

The election results provoked a significant right-leaning shift in territorial power. On the one hand, the collapse of Cs bolstered the electoral support for the PP, making it the most-voted party in around 40% of the municipalities (a 10%-point increase from 2019), 8 out of the 12 Autonomous Communities, as well as in the Autonomous Cities of Ceuta and Melilla. On the other hand, Vox achieved remarkable success, doubling its number of votes in local elections, and significantly increasing its representation in the elected regional assemblies compared to 2019. These electoral outcomes led to significant political changes through numerous municipal and regional government agreements between the PP and Vox (Alonso & Field 2021; Field & Alonso 2023). Consequently, the day after the elections, Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez called for an early general election, stating, ‘Although yesterday’s elections had a municipal and regional scope, the sentiment of the vote carried a message that went

beyond that' (Reuters 2023).

The 2023 local and regional elections in Spain showcased a historically recurrent competitive logic in the country: that of clearly defined ideological blocs (Simón 2020), albeit in its most intense manifestation to date. The electoral presence of the so-called 'new parties' since 2015, notably those advocating radical positions such as Vox and UP, has significantly heightened polarisation in the country (Garmendia Madariaga & Riera 2022; Torcal & Comellas 2022). Consequently, the 2023 elections and their immediate political aftermath offer a valuable case study of a phenomenon that has been largely overlooked in the literature: the potential nationalisation of regional elections in polarised contexts (Abramowitz & Webster 2016). The nature of regional elections in federal and decentralised regimes has been the subject of rich scholarship in the comparative politics literature (Dandoy & Schakel 2013). In this electoral report, we argue that the high levels of polarisation present in Spain nowadays nationalised the 2023 subnational elections to a considerable extent. We present original descriptive evidence on the evolution of the (dis)similarity between electoral results at the national and regional levels to support this claim.

The subsequent sections of the report are structured as follows. The next section provides a detailed account of the events occurring between the multiple elections in 2019 and the campaign of the 2023 regional and local elections. Following that, we delve into the key issues that surfaced during the election campaign. Subsequently, we analyse the outcomes of these subnational elections focusing on the performance of the two main state-wide parties, PP and PSOE, whose basic scope of community solidarity, contrary to non-state-wide parties, is the whole Spain (Molas 1977). After that, given their overall relevance in multilevel government formation, we examine the organisational and electoral dynamics of Cs, UP, and Vox, approximately a decade after their emergence. Once we establish sufficient descriptive context for the 28 May elections, we shift towards a more analytical exploration of the

historical evolution of regional elections in Spain. This analytical exercise is particularly focused on the impact that the post-2015 electoral realignment and resulting political polarisation have had on multilevel party competition in the country. Consequently, our emphasis is on identifying similarities in the results of multilevel elections to elucidate the vertical connections across the national and the regional arenas. Finally, the electoral report concludes with a discussion of some of the most significant insights drawn from the 2023 subnational elections in Spain.

The eventful and contested path towards May 2023 regional and local elections

This section describes the events that took place from the November 2019 national general election and the subsequent formation of the first coalition government at the national level in the recent democratic history of Spain to the campaign of the 2023 regional and local elections. The goal is to do so by underscoring the multiple aspects of this three-year period that contribute to better understanding the Spanish multilevel territorial government and the 2023 election results, which we analyse afterwards.

From the COVID-19 pandemic to the Russian invasion of Ukraine

Never in Spain's democratic history had the country been more exposed to the effects of exogenous crises. While diverse in origin and nature, the COVID-19 pandemic, the volcanic eruption on La Palma Island, and the Russian invasion of Ukraine shook the pillars of competitive politics in the country. Rather than generating a clear and durable 'rally round the flag effect' (De Vries et al. 2021), these events soon brought partisan and social division to these new issues too (Druckman et al. 2021). In fact, as Zanotti and

Turnbull-Dugarte (2022) showed, Spain became the European country with the highest level of party system polarisation on questions related to the pandemic. As we will see below, this unprecedentedly high polarisation decisively affected the outcome of the 2023 local and regional elections.

Barely two months after the formation of the national PSOE-UP coalition government in early 2020, the COVID-19 pandemic outbreak led the newly minted executive to declare, following other European countries, a national lockdown as well as the temporary re-centralisation of regional authority in the sanitary fight against the virus. While the controversy around the timing of these decisions soon became an issue, the largest tensions arose because of the management of the crisis across multiple territorial jurisdictions. The Autonomous Community of Madrid, governed by the PP, led a heated campaign against the legal instrument, the state of alarm, and the restrictions put in place by the national government. Although, the various states of alarm were later declared unconstitutional³, in response to a series of appeals Vox initiated, conflict between regional and central government levels reached particularly high levels between the Spring of 2020 and the Autumn of 2021.

As a way of legitimizing the *ad-hoc* centralised management of the pandemic after the approval of the state of alarm, the Conference of Presidents – an intergovernmental coordination mechanism created in 2004 under then Socialist Prime Minister Zapatero to complement existing sectoral meetings – turned into an important and frequent forum of territorial dialogue during these months that gave regional premier ministers a salient role in crisis-time decision-making.⁴ In fact, a Conference of Presidents was called even after the last of the states of alarm came to an end, when the volcanic eruption in La Palma, in the Canary Islands region, brought another catastrophe to the forefront of political attention in September 2021. Despite its obvious geographic demarcation, the disruptive effects of this event, which displaced 7,000 people, gathered a fair amount of government

action during the following months, including another Conference of Presidents in December 2021. Likewise, immediately after, the Russian invasion of Ukraine brought about an additional Conference of Presidents in the spring of 2022.

However, the unanimous endorsement of some of the initial measures the national government put in place to confront the war soon vanished as inflation, which had already been on the rise because of supply–demand imbalances during the pandemic, continued to increase the cost of basic goods like energy, food, and other products. Despite its lower level in Spain relative to the Eurozone during since the start, inflation had a pervasive effect on the economy beginning in early 2022. Initially, inflation especially affected those sectors vulnerable to changes in the cost of fuel (e.g., transportation). However, as the war continued, the general population was increasingly aware of the loss of purchasing power. Consequently, by the time of the 2023 regional and local elections, ‘the economic crisis’ was the most important problem of the country according to Spaniards⁵ and a recurrent political issue in the public debate. Therefore, the three crises mentioned, the multilevel government responses to them, and the social and political contestation against the government’s measures significantly shaped the political landscape of the May 2023 local and regional elections.

Midterm regional elections

The path towards the 2023 local and regional elections was also importantly shaped by the subnational elections that were held between 2019 and 2023. In this period, Spain went through six regional electoral processes: in the Basque Country and Galicia, which held their elections under the uncertainties of the early days of the pandemic in 2020; in Catalonia and Madrid, which had them in 2021; and in Andalusia and Castilla y León, which did so in 2022. While Andalusia, the Basque Country, Catalonia, and Galicia were

following their regular electoral cycles, elections in Madrid and Castilla y León were called early because of the existing irresolvable tensions between regional coalition government members (PP and Cs) at the time in both regions. Although each of these processes surely deserves a study on its own, our purpose here is to focus on those tendencies that later consolidated in the May 2023 local and regional elections.

- Except for Catalonia, where the regional Prime Minister Quim Torra (*Junts per Catalunya* [United for Catalonia – JxCat, right-wing Catalan nationalist non-state-wide party])⁶ was removed from office for violating the electoral law⁷ and the Socialist Party and *Esquerra Republicana de Catalunya* (Republican Left of Catalonia – ERC, left-wing Catalan nationalist non-state-wide party) performed particularly well in the subsequent elections, in the rest of the regions the main incumbent party won the elections and improved its number of votes and/or seats, which presents interesting food for thought for those scholars interested in understanding multilevel accountability processes during times of crisis.
- In fact, some of these incumbent victories were particularly large, as, for instance, in Andalusia and Galicia, where the PP obtained a majority of the seats in both assemblies.
- Except for Galicia, where Vox continued to have no representation, the radical right party experienced a clear improvement in its results everywhere else, obtaining seats for the first time in the Basque Country and Catalonia, and becoming PP's coalition partner in Castilla y León.
- UP and Cs experienced clear territorial retrenchment. In the case of the latter, this meant disappearing in both Andalusia and Madrid – where Cs went from having government responsibilities to no representation – and transitioning from being the most voted list to losing almost all its representation in Catalonia.

Leadership changes

The results of the above-mentioned regional elections also relevantly re-shaped the organisation of most state-wide parties in Spain during this period. Specifically, Cs, PP, and UP changed their national leadership as a direct or an indirect consequence of these elections, evidencing the clear connection between arenas.

The call for an early regional election in the spring of 2021 in the region of Madrid had immediate and direct consequences for UP. After its heavy losses in the Basque Country and Galicia, and as a way of boosting its overall negative prospects that polls were depicting for the party in the Madrid elections, Pablo Iglesias, the national leader of the party and the Second Deputy Prime Minister of the national coalition government, decided to step down and become the regional candidate of UP. Moreover, he appointed the then Minister of Labour, Yolanda Díaz, as the new leader of this radical left coalition of parties. The competition to the left of PSOE was particularly fierce in this region given the existence of Más Madrid (More Madrid),⁸ a regional party that former UP members had created for the 2019 local and regional elections in Madrid. With Iglesias running, Unidas Podemos improved its number of votes and seats in the 2021 Madrid regional elections. However, his candidacy was not enough to significantly boost the party's electoral performance. UP obtained the lowest number of seats among the parties that entered the regional chamber, and the overall disappointing results pushed Iglesias out of institutional politics.

The results of the 2021 Madrid elections also had relevant consequences for the PP. Isabel Díaz Ayuso, who had become the prime minister of the region in 2019 thanks to a coalition agreement with Cs, obtained a clear victory that confirmed her role as a strong leader in and outside her region and political party. As the most critical voice of the national government's performance during the pandemic, Ayuso defended an alternative and less

restrictive way of fighting the COVID-19 virus which gained momentum before and after these regional elections. Her rapid rise soon became a challenge for the PP's national leader, Pablo Casado, who since his appointment in 2018 had never enjoyed high levels of popularity. After months of public disagreements between the national and the regional leadership boards of the party, a final dispute in the beginning of 2022 around the role of Ayuso's brother in a pandemic equipment related public tender in the region of Madrid made Casado lose the support of his party. In April 2022, the PP celebrated an Extraordinary Party Convention that elected the prime minister of Galicia, Alberto Núñez Feijóo, as the new leader of the organisation.

The last state-wide party leadership changes in this period was also indirectly connected to this period's midterm regional elections. Between 2019 and 2023, Cs experienced two leadership transitions. The call of the snap regional elections in Madrid in spring 2021 was a reaction to a PSOE and Cs initiative to jointly support votes of no confidence to oust PP from power in the regions of Murcia and Madrid. Both attempts failed to change the governments in these regions and, thus, contributed to erode even more the intra-party support for Cs' leader, Inés Arrimadas. Arrimadas, who had led Cs into becoming the most voted party in Catalonia in 2017, left Catalan politics in 2019 to become a member of the Spanish Parliament. She was soon elected the party's leader in 2020 after Albert Rivera decided to abandon politics. Although she won the party's primaries defending Rivera's veto of any alliance agreement with PSOE, Cs' support of the national coalition government's states of alarm, as well as its negotiations with PSOE in Madrid and Murcia, led a number of party cadres to abandon the party. The adverse results of the snap 2021 regional elections in Madrid and the 2022 elections in Castilla y León confirmed the party's continued decline and brought it to an important redefinition of its goals and

strategies that made Arrimadas abandon politics in the beginning of 2023, being replaced by Patricia Guasp.

Figure 1 displays state-wide party leaders' weighted popularity ratings (1-10, with 10 being the highest popularity) according to the survey data gathered by the *Centro de Investigaciones Sociológicas* (CIS) during the 2019-2022 period.⁹ The graph serves to compare the popularity of main state-wide party leaders over time, as well as to understand the suitability of leadership transitions in Cs, PP, and UP. The data appear to suggest that in all three cases the change brought a relatively more popular leader into these organisations. It also shows how these changes generally narrowed the gaps in leaders' popularity across parties, suggesting that there was an overall increase in electoral competitiveness in this period.

[Figure 1 about here]

A nationalised and heated campaign

Two main characteristics describe the 2023 regional and local elections campaign: the nationalisation of campaign issues and the relatively high levels of party system polarisation. Regarding the former, and as also happened in the 2011 and 2015 electoral cycles, the fact that the general elections were to be held after the regional and local elections gave the whole process a strong national taste, pushing, in many cases, regional and local issues into the background. The main opposition state-wide parties (PP, Vox, and Cs) framed these elections as a general referendum on the national coalition government's performance and legislative alliances. The main national coalition government members (PSOE and UP) defended the suitability of their policy initiatives

and performance in the particularly eventful and adverse above-explained context. Probably the best example of the shared strategy to nationalise these elections was the recurrent presence of both PSOE and PP national leaders (Pedro Sánchez and Alberto Núñez Feijóo) in dozens of events throughout Spanish territory during the campaign.

As for party system polarisation, several campaign events contributed to push its already comparatively and longitudinally exceptional levels (Dalton 2021; Zanotti & Turnbull-Dugarte 2022) to the limit. In fact, the campaign was eclipsed from the beginning by the decision of *Euskal Herria Bildu* (Basque Country United – EH Bildu) – the radical left Basque nationalist non-state-wide party (NSWP)– to include on its electoral lists 44 convicted members of the extinct ETA terrorist group, seven of which had been sentenced for killings.¹⁰ The support of this political party for many of the legislative initiatives of PSOE and UP in the Congress of Deputies since 2020 soon brought the issue of terrorism into play. While the complaints by the main opposition state-wide parties around the ‘legislative connection’ between EH Bildu and the central government incumbents had been a constant since the 2019 electoral cycle, EH Bildu’s sudden decision to bring convicted terrorists into politics elevated the tone and temperature of public discourse. Vox asked for the party to be banned. ‘¡Que te vote Txapote!’ (Let Txapote Vote for You!)¹¹ – a political slogan against PSOE that was marginally popular among the radical right in Spain up till then – became a motto of not only Vox, but also in PP’s campaigns in several regions and cities.

The second main campaign issue revolved around right-wing parties’ claims about electoral fraud committed by the Socialist incumbent government. The suspected existence of cases of vote buying in cities like Melilla or Mojacar (Andalusia), among a few others, most of which were connected to PSOE’s candidates or local coalition partners, allowed, mainly Vox, but also some PP cadres, to raise doubts about the integrity of the whole

electoral process. Following other recent international examples of electoral fraud claims (e.g., in the US during the 2020 presidential election campaign), the issue was largely focused on the functioning of the state-owned *Correos*, the company responsible for providing public postal service in Spain. This issue also would relevantly shape the posterior July 23rd general elections. The relative importance of terrorism and electoral fraud was clearly confirmed in the last campaign event of PP's national leader, Núñez Feijóo, in Madrid when Isabel Díaz Ayuso, the region's prime minister who was running for re-election, publicly claimed that 'Sánchez will leave as he arrived: rigging' since 'not even Txapote will vote for him' (Roces 2023).

In response to the right-wing parties' attacks, PSOE and UP attempted to focus their overall campaign on policies and the national government's performance, while also engaging in competition with one another by striving to capitalize on their respective successes. For instance, the approval of the new national Housing Law during the electoral campaign, and the debate around increasing housing prices and the role of state intervention in regulating the market pushed the various political parties to take a position on this issue. However, these matters, including the pension reform, did not achieve the same level of centrality as terrorism and electoral fraud did. Consequently, negative campaigning became prevalent across the political spectrum. For members of the national coalition government, this meant centring their campaigns on the potential adversities that a victory by 'the right' could bring across various regions and municipalities in the country.

The results of May 2023 regional and local elections

The realignment that the Spanish party system experienced beginning in 2015 (Vidal 2018) made the new state-wide parties (Cs, UP, and Vox) an indispensable asset for traditional mainstream state-wide parties (PP and PSOE) when they lacked a parliamentary majority, particularly in regions without strong non-state-wide parties. Therefore, the appearance of these parties initiated a process by which Autonomous Communities started to be separated into left- and right-wing blocs and that was consolidated in the 2019 regional and local elections (Simón 2019).¹² In accordance with this competitive logic, state-wide parties would primarily seek to forge alliances with parties ideologically aligned with them, thereby exacerbating inter-territorial ideological divisions.

In the campaign of the May 2023 elections, the two-bloc logic reached its most extreme manifestation. Similar to the trend observed since 2015, the election results were significantly influenced by the performance of the ‘new parties’. The virtual disappearance of Cs, the electoral decline of UP, and the territorial consolidation of Vox between 2019 and 2023 reshaped the regional political landscape. Although notably more fragmented (Rodon, 2020), this landscape bore a striking resemblance to that of 2011 when PSOE lost most of its regional and local governments to PP in the early days of the Great Recession. However, unlike that occasion, PSOE did not suffer a major electoral setback this time. Nevertheless, the shift in the vote of former Cs supporters towards PP was sufficient for the latter to become the most popular party in many competitive races. PP’s surge in electoral support allowed the party to secure the government in numerous capital cities¹³ and obtain a significant portion of legislative seats in the elected regional parliaments. Moreover, wherever that boost was not enough, the enhanced regional presence of Vox granted PP the

potential to reach government through region-specific governing agreements. Table 1 displays information on the 12 autonomous communities and 2 autonomous cities where elections were held.¹⁴

[Table 1 about here]

Therefore, when Pedro Sánchez called for early general elections on the morning of May 29th, 2023, PSOE had lost its majority of the legislative seats in Extremadura and a potential coalition with parties to its left no longer reached a majority in five Autonomous Communities where it had led a government until then (Aragón, Balearic Islands, Canary Islands, La Rioja, and Valencia). As a result, nowadays, PP holds a parliamentary majority in four Autonomous Communities (Andalusia, Galicia, La Rioja, and Madrid). It is the majority coalition partner in five other regional governments jointly (mainly) with Vox (Aragón, Castilla y León, Extremadura, Murcia, and Valencia), and it leads minority governments in two Autonomous Communities (Balearic Islands and Cantabria) (see the increasingly dark regional map of Spain between 2019 and 2023 in Figure 2). After the 2023 local and regional elections, PSOE only holds the majority in Castilla-La Mancha, and it is the majority coalition partner in Asturias and Navarre. In fact, the decision to call for snap general elections has been widely interpreted as a strategic move by the national coalition partners to capitalize on the PP's proven readiness to form alliances with the radical right party Vox when deemed necessary, an almost unprecedented phenomenon in Western Europe that could scare the moderate voter (Field & Alonso 2023).

[Figure 2 about here]

The electoral ebb and flow of ‘new parties’

Given the crucial role of the so-called ‘new parties’ on multilevel coalition government formation after 2015, the following lines delve into their regional representation before and after May 2023. It examines their institutional presence at the sub-national level almost 10 years after their appearance.¹⁵

Chronicle of death foretold: The end of Ciudadanos

2023 regional and local elections confirmed the virtual disappearance of Cs. The party obtained no seats in any of the elected regional assemblies and lost 85% of its municipal representatives (falling from 2,787 councillors in 2019 to 392 in 2023).¹⁶ With only 9 regional members of parliament left (two in the Basque Country, six in Catalonia, and one in Castilla y León), the territorial representation of this political party as of 2023 is the most extreme historical example of electoral volatility in the country. Only four years before, in the 2019 local and regional elections, Cs had become the third largest Spanish party in terms of territorial representation and was the junior coalition partner in the PP-led governments of Andalusia, Castilla y León, Madrid, and Murcia (see Table 2 for a detailed evolution on the party’s territorial representation from 2015 to 2023).

Two days after the elections, the party’s National Committee decided not to run for the 2023 snap general elections, stating that it was clear that Spaniards did not see their organisation as a ‘good and transformative alternative’ (Martínez 2023). With this decision, Cs chose to concede in advance the loss of its 10 seats in the Spanish lower chamber, Congress of Deputies, and follow the path of *Unión, Progreso y Democracia* (Union, Progress and Democracy/UPyD), which after losing its national representation in 2015, continued its activity at the local, regional, and European levels, as long as it had

representation, until its dissolution in 2020. Cs then replicated the short trajectories of previously self-proclaimed ‘liberal’ parties in Spain, that is, former prime minister Adolfo Suárez’s *Centro Democrático y Social* (Democratic and Social Center/CDS) and Rosa Díez’s UPyD (Rodríguez Teruel & Barrio 2016), and opened the door, as a result, to a potential re-unification of all the centre-right vote under the PP label.

[Table 2 about here]

The uncertain future of Spanish radical left: From Podemos to Unidas Podemos, and then Sumar

The electoral decline of this national electoral coalition, and its territorial allies (‘*confluencias*’ or confluences),¹⁷ started to be evident in the 2019 local and regional elections, when, among other results, it went from being a government coalition member to obtaining no representation in Castilla-La Mancha and lost the control of cities like Madrid. The story around the electoral defeat of Más Madrid in the latter serves as a good example of a recurrent weakness of UP since its inception: factionalism and its effects on the party’s policy positions, strategies, electoral performance, and even survival (Lourenço, Conceição & Jalali 2023). Months before the 2019 local elections, the battle for the control of the organisation in the country’s capital city had led to the creation of Más Madrid, a sequel of Ahora Madrid (Madrid Now), the Madrid ‘confluencia’ of Podemos that had been running the city government since 2015. Más Madrid was the first political organisation created outside the control of the national leader of Podemos, Pablo Iglesias, who, as a reaction, canvassed for his own alternative party lists in the 2019 local and regional elections. The outcome was far from flattering: Más Madrid fell short of the necessary support to continue governing the city and Iglesias’ party candidate did not attain any representation.

The local structure of Podemos has always been quite convoluted. In 2015, the party avoided running in local elections because possible conflicts in the making of electoral lists had the potential to jeopardize the nascent organisation (Rodríguez-Teruel, Barrio & Barberà 2016) and its decentralised and deliberative nature (Lisi 2019). While Podemos benefited a great deal as a result in those first municipal elections – it took credit for the victories of ideologically close electoral lists despite not formally running – it also planted the seed for highly autonomous local organisations in subsequent elections, independent from hierarchical discipline. The regional structure of the party has followed a more formal path, but, as Table 3 shows, it has also suffered from numerous divisions and re-branding processes in almost every single Autonomous Community ever since 2015. At the regional level, Podemos' electoral strategies were mainly two back then: 1) the party used its national brand in regions without significant NSWPs and in those regions with significant NSWPs that held elections in May 2015, or 2) it formed alliances with existing regional organisations wherever the NSWPs were strong and elections were held later (Rodríguez-Teruel, Barrio & Barberà 2016). In 2019, Podemos ran almost everywhere with its new national electoral coalition partners, the radical left Izquierda Unida (United Left/IU)¹⁸ and the green party EQUO, though at that time Podemos had already suffered from splits in Madrid. The latter also happened later in Galicia and Andalusia, where its local branches' parliamentary groups, *En Marea* (In Tide)¹⁹ and *Adelante Andalucía*²⁰ (Forward Andalusia) respectively, suffered from deep factional battles that ended up splitting these organisations.

The leadership transition did not improve the divisive nature of UP in the run-up to the May 2023 elections. Pablo Iglesias' appointment of Yolanda Díaz as his successor in 2021 soon led to internal conflict. UP combined very diverse political trajectories. Díaz was not a formal member of Podemos but came from the Communist side of the UP

alliance. She and the members of the national board of Podemos, some of which were also members of the national coalition government, publicly showed their disagreements, particularly after Díaz decided to create her own alternative organisation to run for the 2023 general elections. *Sumar*, launched to reunite the atomised spectrum of the radical left in Spain (Fernández Vila 2022), was registered in the spring of 2022 as a political association and in the spring of 2023 as a political organisation. Nonetheless, the new party did not run in the 2023 regional and local elections, leaving this arena entirely to UP's regional and local branches and the rest of the already existing left-wing organisations. The results of the May 2023 local and regional elections were heterogeneous but overall negative for the radical left in Spain. It lost a considerable number of representatives and, consequently, was pushed out of government in several regions, which generated even more uncertainties about its future electoral prospects.

[Table 3 about here]

The Spanish way: The normalisation of the radical right

Once considered to be no country for the radical right (Alonso & Rovira Kaltwasser 2015), Spain has become a quite unique comparative case study when it comes to the electoral appeal of the radical right (Rama et al. 2021). The comparatively higher relevance of the Spanish radical right is largely explained by the government formation patterns followed in this country in recent times. Though after the 2019 local and regional elections almost all the coalition governments followed a clear left-right bloc logic, the formation of the 2019 national cabinet between PSOE and UP importantly consolidated this division (Orriols & León 2020). Indeed, the governmental presence of UP presented a comparative exception – only Greece (the Syriza-ANEL coalition, 2015-2019) had had

a populist radical left party in a national government since 1972 in a West European country.²¹

Therefore, the practical disappearance of Cs and the territorial consolidation of Vox made the question of what to do with the radical right more salient and divisive than in other neighbouring countries. In the absence of the former liberal party, the two-bloc logic implied an even more polarised scenario in which, wherever the PP did not get a majority of the seats in a regional parliament, the temptation to govern with the radical right arose (see Table 4 for a complete account of Vox's territorial representation from 2015 to 2023). This was the case after 2021 Madrid elections when Vox tended to grant its legislative support to PP although staying outside government, and after the 2022 elections in Castilla y León when Vox granted its support to PP in exchange for specific cabinet positions. The latter 'right-to-far-right' governing coalition, the first of its kind in the recent democratic history of the country and another exception when compared to national government formation in Western Europe after the Great Recession (Riera & Pastor 2022),²² served as a precursor for the governing pacts after the 2023 local and regional elections.

Despite the overall success of PP in the elections, the fragmentation of the vote across territories opened the door to the generalisation of these governing agreements (Alonso and Field, 2021; Field and Alonso, 2023). PP and Vox signed 140 local-level governing pacts, including in 6 provincial capitals (Burgos, Ciudad Real, Guadalajara, Huelva, Toledo, and Valladolid). Moreover, PP and Vox signed four coalition government agreements in Extremadura, Valencia, Aragón, and Murcia, and an investiture agreement for Vox to support a PP minority government in the Balearic Islands. Most of these agreements involve explicit changes to what not long ago seemed to be consensual positions shared by most political parties in Spain. In fact, Vox's radical stances go beyond opposing external migration. In Castilla y León, Balearic Islands, and

Valencia, Vox forced a change in the definition of domestic violence, transforming it into an ‘intra-family’ issue, and the party has initiated a campaign to limit public institutional support for the LGBTQ+ movement.

[Table 4 about here]

Regional elections in polarised times in Spain

The evidence presented so far has shown how fragmented and volatile regional electoral competition in Spain has been ever since 2015, when three new state-wide parties made their appearance in multilevel elections in this country, alongside the existing numerous and increasingly strong NSWPs (Beramendi & Máiz 2004). It has also indicated how, with few exceptions, there has been a progressive regional substitution of the liberal Cs by the radical right Vox in the right-wing bloc as the third most voted party. This has contributed to increasing even further the level of political polarisation nowadays in Spain. These developments bring us to a more general and relevant question in the comparative politics literature: to what extent do these transformations have an impact on our theoretical and empirical understanding of how regional elections function in a federal or decentralised regime (Dandoy & Schakel 2013)? In the next pages, we claim that the extraordinarily high levels of political polarisation considerably nationalised parties’ strategies and voters’ behaviour in the 2023 local and regional elections.

In a 2016 piece, Abramowitz and Webster showed that in the United States of America there is an increasingly strong correlation between negative partisanship – voters’ negative ratings of the opposing party – and voters’ loyalty in voting for their preferred party. This phenomenon, as they illustrated, is reflected through a simultaneous

rise in straight ticket voting and the connection between the outcomes of presidential elections and those of the House, Senate, and even state legislative elections. According to the authors, ‘to a greater extent than at any time in the post-World War II era, the outcomes of elections below the presidential level reflect the outcomes of presidential elections’ (Abramowitz and Webster 2016, p. 12). The implications of the latter are particularly relevant, since the USA has always been seen as a prototypical example of a country in which sub-national elections have been considered ‘balancing’ processes, where national incumbent parties experience dips of support that are independent from other factors such as the economy (Erikson & Filippov 2001).

Growing political polarisation, thus, might explain changes in the (dis)similarity of election results across different territorial arenas in the absence of institutional or other political changes in competition, as for instance, an increase or decrease in party system fragmentation. While the argument for high election congruence in the presence of a two-party system seems an obvious one, explaining an equivalent phenomenon in multilevel elections with multiparty systems at each level becomes certainly more complicated. Following the literature on polarisation and its consequences for party competition in multiparty systems, party system polarisation should manifest through a higher similarity in total vote shares for each ideological bloc across different territorial arenas. That is, as polarisation in a political system increases, the ideological blocs should be more likely to obtain the same levels of electoral support across levels of government, regardless of the potential role of election timing or other relevant campaign related aspects (Rodden & Wibbels 2011; Moskowitz 2021).

To assess the extent to which party system polarisation influences the dis(similarity) of multilevel election results in Spain, we present an analysis of this phenomenon from the 1979 general elections to the 2023 regional elections. We are

certainly not the first ones to work on the prevalence of this issue in Spain (Montero & Font 1991; Liñeira 2011; Gómez Fortes & Cabeza Pérez 2013; Riera 2013). Yet below we present the most complete account of it up until today. The comparison between parties' vote shares in regional and national elections we propose here is widely used to assess regional distinctiveness, that is, the level of disconnection of citizens' electoral behaviour between the national and the regional arenas (see for example Jeffery & Hough 2003; Dandoy & Schakel 2013). The employed index here is identical to Pedersen's index of electoral volatility (Pedersen 1979). But, rather than comparing an election with another election held previously in time at the same level (either national or regional), we compare a regional election to the previous national general election. The dissimilarity index is calculated by taking the sum of absolute differences between national and regional vote shares for each party in each region and subsequently dividing the sum by two. The formula is given by:

$$\text{Dissimilarity} = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^n |X_{iNt} - X_{iRt}|$$

where X_{iN} is the percentage of the vote won by party i in a given national election N , and X_{iR} is the percentage of the vote won by party i in the very next regional election R after the national election of reference. Once we have calculated this score for each pair of general and regional elections in each region, we average it and display the results by general election. Scores may vary from complete congruence/similarity (0) to complete incongruence/dissimilarity (100%).

Figure 3 shows the evolution of the national average index's scores over time (squares). It also incorporates a second time trend with the same index's scores calculated only taking into account the dissimilarity in vote between the two main state-wide

ideological (left and right) blocs (circles) across arenas.²³ Four milestones can be distinguished in the first trend: 1) the relatively important dissimilarity in election results across national and regional arenas in 1979 due to the fact that in the period between 1979 and 1982 only fast-track regions (Basque Country, Catalonia, Galicia and Andalusia), where strong non-state-wide parties exist, had regional elections; 2) the comparatively similar election results across arenas in the period between 1982 to 2004, when the values of the score consistently remain modest, regardless of the decentralisation reforms that allowed NSWPs to gain momentum and widened the opportunities for supporting different political options in each electoral arena; 3) the increasing dissimilarity across arenas in the 2008 and 2011 electoral cycles, when, due to the Great Recession, national incumbents (PSOE in 2008 and PP in 2011) suffered considerable vote losses to IU and UPyD first, and then to Podemos and Ciudadanos in subsequent regional elections; and 4) the even more similar results somewhat decreasing gap after 2015, when the index's score goes down, despite the evident increase in party system fragmentation (Rodon 2020) – which should, in principle, increase the potential space for dissimilarity.

The second time trend provides an alternative measure of dissimilarity, which presents a much more nuanced picture of this phenomenon after 2015. Two main conclusions can be derived from it. First, the score of the inter-bloc election dissimilarity index is practically the same as the total one up until 2008, suggesting that vote switching across arenas happens both within and across ideological blocs with the same strength. Second, after the Great Recession, a considerable gap emerges across indices that still exists nowadays. After that moment, voters become more likely to vote for different parties across arenas, but only if the latter belong to the same ideological bloc. This divergence in the scores of the two indices is due to two elements present in the Spanish political landscape in the last decade. On the one hand, as party system fragmentation

increases, the room for higher overall dissimilarity goes up. However, on the other hand, because of rampant political polarisation,²⁴ potential electoral fluctuations across arenas happen within rather than between ideological blocs.

[Figure 3 about here]

Conclusions

The 2023 regional and local elections had far-reaching consequences for Spanish politics. The clear territorial defeat of both national coalition members compelled Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez to announce an early general election. This report began by exploring the complexities of the period leading up to these elections, emphasizing its momentous and turbulent nature. Additionally, the report delved into the May 2023 electoral campaign, a highly charged political process imbued with a strong national flavour due to the proximity of the general elections. The tone of the public debate, the issues that were raised, and the recurrent presence of leaders from the main state-wide parties at various campaign events across the Spanish territory contributed to making this campaign extraordinarily polarised and nationalised. These events also solidified a competitive logic – characterised by two distinct ideological blocs – that had never been as intense.

The election results triggered a significant right-leaning shift in territorial power. Indeed, the widespread turnover of regional and local governments following this vote was closely tied to the electoral performance of the so-called 'new parties' in the system, which were experiencing markedly different momentum at the time of the vote. While Cs, the centre-liberal party, lost virtually all its territorial representation, significantly boosting support for PP, the two main radical parties in the system, UP and Vox, were

undergoing opposite electoral trajectories. The former was embroiled in an intense factional conflict related to its leadership and strategy in the upcoming general elections, resulting in a clear territorial retrenchment in these elections, whereas the latter, after years of unsuccessful attempts, finally established itself at the subnational level. The results of these new parties defined PSOE and PP's chances of signing coalition or investiture agreements across regions and cities, thereby clearly shaping their territory-based institutional power.

Given the evident interconnection between multilevel electoral arenas in 2023, the report concluded by shedding new light on a broader comparative politics question: whether political polarisation influences the nationalisation of party competition in established democracies. An in-depth examination of the evolution of dissimilarity scores, capturing the level of nationalisation of electoral politics since 1979, confirmed a trend of vote nationalisation in Spain in the last three electoral cycles (2015-2016, 2016-2019, and 2019-2023). This occurred despite the increase in party system fragmentation, which typically implies a greater potential for dual voting. Notably, political polarisation played a significant role, as evidenced by the gap between total dissimilarity and inter-bloc dissimilarity: the results indicated that vertical election dissimilarity since 2015 occurred primarily within blocs. These findings constitute original evidence of vote nationalisation processes in highly polarised contexts with multiparty systems. They also suggest that in a scenario where the two-bloc logic is so prevalent, inter-bloc pacts might become quite costly. The latter might help understand the increasing difficulties for political parties belonging to different ideological blocs to reach agreements in Spain.

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Tables

Table 1. Results of the 28 May 2023 regional elections.

Region/Party	PSOE	PP	Vox	UP	NSWP-1	NSWP-2	NSWP-3	NSWP-4	Total Seats
Aragón	29.5 (23)	35.5 (28)	11.2 (7)	Podemos- AV: 4 (1)	CHA: 5.1 (3)	AE: 5 (3)	PAR: 2.1 (1)		67
				IU: 3.1 (1)					
Asturias	36.5 (19)	32.6 (17)	10.1 (3)	IU: 7.6 (3)	Foro: 3.6 (1)				45
				Podemos: 3.9 (1)					
Balearic Islands	26.5 (18)	35.8 (25)	13.9 (8)	UP: 4.4 (1)	Més per Mallorca: 8.3 (4)	Més per Menorca: 1.4 (2)	Sa Unió de Formentera: 0.4 (1)		59
Canary Islands	32.4 (23)	20.1 (15)	7.9 (4)		CCa: 19.2 (19)	NC-BC: 7.1 (5)	ASG: 0.7 (3)	AHI: 0.2 (1)	70
Cantabria	20.6 (8)	35.8 (15)	11.1 (4)		PRC: 20.8 (8)				35
Castilla-La Mancha	45.04 (17)	33.65 (12)	12.83 (4)						33
Extremadura	39.9 (28)	38.8 (28)	8.1 (5)	6 (4)					65
Madrid	18.2 (27)	47.3 (70)	7.3 (11)		Más Madrid- Verdes-Equo: 18.4 (27)				136
Murcia	25.6 (13)	42.8 (21)	17.7 (9)	4.7 (2)					45
Navarra	20.7 (11)	7.3 (3)	4.3 (2)	6.1 (3)	UPN: 28 (15)	EH- Bildu: 17.1 (9)	Geroa Bai: 13.2 (7)		50
La Rioja	31.9 (12)	45.4 (17)	7.6 (2)	5.1 (2)					33
Valencia	28.7 (31)	35.8 (40)	12.6 (13)		Compromís: 14.5 (15)				99
Ceuta	21 (6)	34.4 (9)	20.6 (5)		MDyC: 11.2 (3)	Ceuta Ya!: 10 (2)			25
Melilla	10.7 (3)	52.7 (14)	9.9 (2)		CpM: 18.8 (5)	Somos Melilla: 5.1 (1)			25

Note: These are vote shares with number of seats in parentheses. CHA (Chunta Aragonesista), AE (Aragon Existe), PAR (Partido Aragonesista), CCa (Coalición Canaria), NC-BC (Nueva Canarias-Bloque Canarista), ASG (Agrupación Socialista Gomera), AHI (Agrupación Herreña Independiente), PRC (Partido Regionalista Cántabro), UPN (Unión del Pueblo Navarro), MDyC (Movimiento por la Dignidad y la Ciudadanía) and CpM (Coalición por Melilla).

Table 2. The regional representation of Ciudadanos from 2015 to 2023.

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Andalusia	8.2 (109)			19.3 (109)				0 (109)	
Aragón	7.5 (67)				17.9 (67)				0 (67)
Asturias	6.7 (45)				11.1 (45)				0 (45)
Balearic Islands	3.4 (59)				8.5 (59)				0 (59)
Basque Country		0 (75)				2.7 (75)			
Canary Islands	0 (60)				2.8 (70)				0 (70)
Cantabria	5.7 (35)				8.6 (35)				0 (35)
Castilla-La Mancha	0 (33)				12.1 (33)				0 (33)
Castilla y León	5.9 (84)				14.3 (84)			1.2 (84)	
Catalonia	18.5 (135)		26.7 (135)				4.4 (135)		
Extremadura	1.5 (65)				10.8 (65)				0 (65)
Galicia		0 (75)				0 (75)			
Madrid	13.2 (129)			19.7 (132)			0 (136)		0 (135)
Murcia	8.9 (45)				13.3 (45)				0 (45)
Navarra	0 (50)				0 (50)				0 (50)
La Rioja	12.1 (33)				12.1 (33)				0 (33)
Valencia	13.1 (99)				18.2 (99)				0 (99)
Ceuta	4 (25)				0 (25)				0 (25)
Melilla	8 (25)				4 (25)				0 (25)

Note: These are seat shares of Cs with total number of seats in the Regional Assembly in parentheses.

Table 3. Spain's radical left and its regional representation from 2015 to 2023.

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Andalusia	Podemos 13.8; IU-Los Verdes- Convocatoria por Andalucía 4.6 (109)			Adelante Andalucía 15.6 (109)				Por Andalucía 4.6; Adelante Andalucía 1.8 (109)	
Aragón	Podemos 20.9; IU 1.5 (67)				Podemos-Equo 7.5; IU 1.5 (67)				Podemos-AV 1.5; IU 1.5 (67)
Asturias	Podemos 20; IU 11.1 (45)				Podemos 8.9; IU-Izq. Asturiana 4.4 (45)				Podemos 2.2; IU-Izq. Asturiana-Más País 6.7 (45)
Balearic Islands	Podem 16.9; Guayem (EU) 0 (59)				U. Podem 10.2 (59)				U. Podem 1.7 (59)
Basque Country		Podemos/Ahal Dugu-IU 14.7 (75)				Podemos/Ahal Dugu-IU 8 (75)			
Canary Islands	Podemos 11.7; Canarias Decide (IU) 0 (60)				Sí Podemos 5.7; IU 0 (70)				U. Sí Podemos 0; Drago Verde 0 (70)
Cantabria	Podemos 8.6; IU 0 (35)				Podemos 0; Marea Cantabria (IU-Equo) 0 (35)				Podemos-IU 0 (35)
Castilla-La Mancha	Podemos 6.1; Ganemos (LV- IU) 0 (33)				U. Podemos 0 (33)				U. Podemos 0 (33)
Castilla y León	Podemos 11.9; IU 1.2 (84)				Podemos-Equo 2.4; IU 0 (84)			U. Podemos 1.2 (84)	
Catalonia	Catalunya Sí Que es Pot 8.1 (135)		Catalunya En Comú Podem 5.9 (135)				En Comú Podem 5.9 (135)		
Extremadura	Podemos 9.2; Ganemos (IU- LV) 0 (65)				U. por Extremadura 6.1 (65)				U. por Extremadura 6.1 (65)
Galicia		En Marea 18.7 (75)				En Común- Anova 0 (75)			
Madrid	Podemos 21; IU-LV 0 (129)				Más Madrid 15.1; Podemos- IU 5.3 (132)		Más Madrid 17.6; Podemos- IU 7.3 (136)	Más Madrid 20; Podemos-IU 0 (135)	
Murcia	Podemos 13.3; Ganar (IU) 0 (45)				Podemos-Equo 4.4; Cambiar (IU) 0 (45)				Podemos-IU 4.4 (45)
Navarra	Podemos-Ahal Dugu 14; Izquierda- Ezkerria (IU) 4 (50)				Podemos-Ahal Dugu 4; Izquierda- Ezkerria (IU) 2 (50)				Contigo Navarra 6 (50)
La Rioja	Podemos 12.1; Cambiar (IU- Equo) 0 (33)				U. Podemos 6.1 (33)				U. Podemos 6.1 (33)
Valencia	Podem 13.1; Acord Ciutadà (EU) 0 (99)				U. Podem 8.1 (99)				U. Podem 0 (99)
Ceuta	x				U. Podemos 0 (25)				Podemos 0 (25)
Melilla	Podemos 0 (25)				U. Podemos 0 (25)				x

Note: These are seat shares or radical left parties with total number of seats in the Regional Assembly in parentheses. For the explanation of some alliances, see footnotes from 17 to 20. In most cases, these are coalitions

of the two main radical left parties (Podemos and IU) with some small green parties (e.g., Los Verdes [LV], Equo, Alianza Verde [AV], etc.) In some cases, languages other than Spanish are used in the names.

Table 4. The regional representation of Vox from 2015 to 2023.

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Andalusia	0 (109)			11 (109)				12.8 (109)	
Aragón	–				4.5 (67)				10.4 (67)
Asturias	0 (45)				4.4 (45)				8.9 (45)
Balearic Islands	0 (59)				5.1 (59)				13.5 (59)
Basque Country		0 (75)				1.33 (75)			
Canary Islands	0 (60)				0 (70)				5.7 (70)
Cantabria	0 (35)				5.7 (35)				11.4 (35)
Castilla-La Mancha	0 (33)				0 (33)				12.1 (33)
Castilla y León	0 (81)				1.2 (81)			16 (81)	
Catalonia	–		–				8.1 (135)		
Extremadura	0 (65)				0 (65)				7.7 (65)
Galicia		–				0 (75)			
Madrid	0 (129)			9.1 (132)			9.5 (136)		8.1 (135)
Murcia	0 (45)				8.9 (45)				20 (45)
Navarra	–				0 (50)				4 (50)
La Rioja	–				0 (33)				6.1 (33)
Valencia	0 (99)				10.1 (99)				13.1 (99)
Ceuta	0 (25)				24 (25)				20 (25)
Melilla	–				8 (25)				8 (25)

Note: These are seat shares of Vox with total number of seats in the Regional Assembly in parentheses.

Figures

Figure 1. State-wide party leaders' popularity ratings.

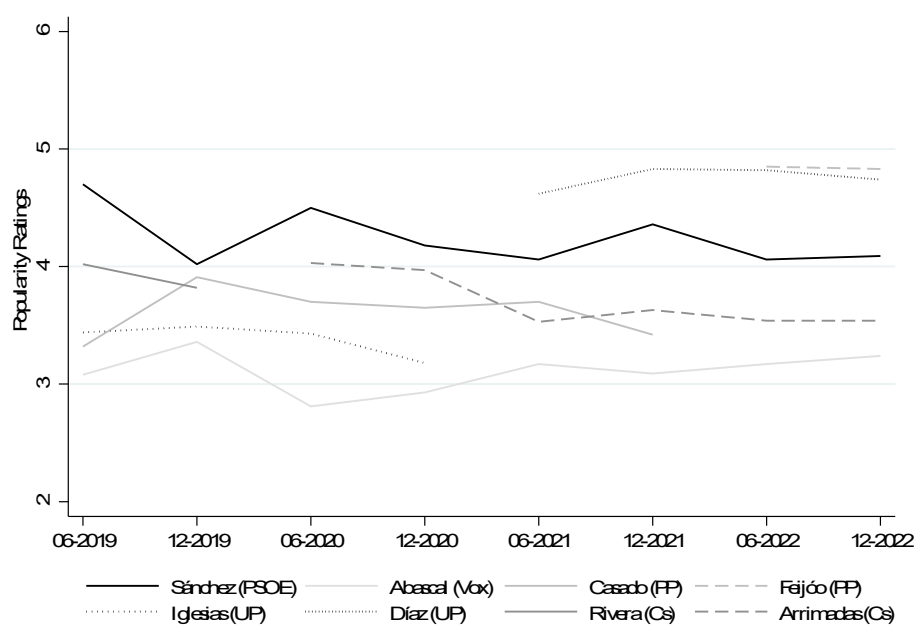


Figure 2. Map of partisan control of regional governments in Spain between 2019 and 2023.

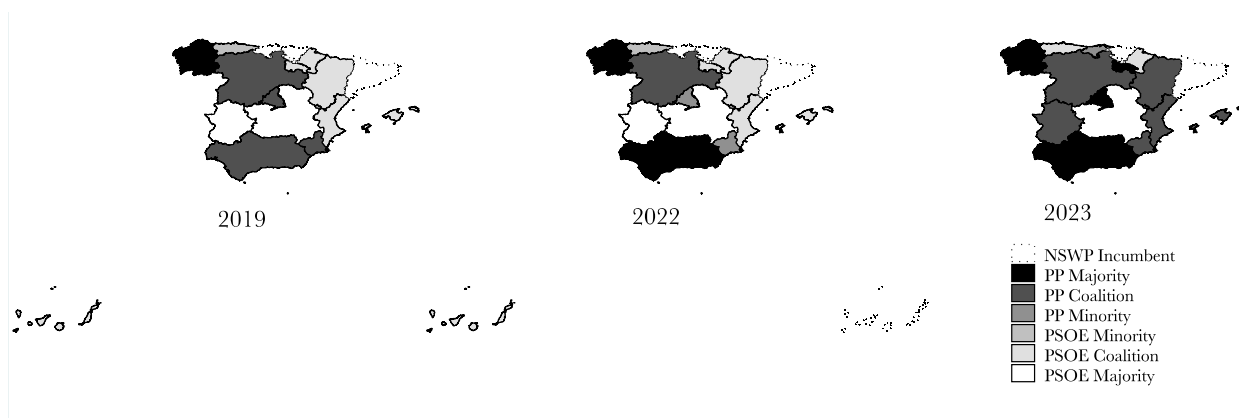
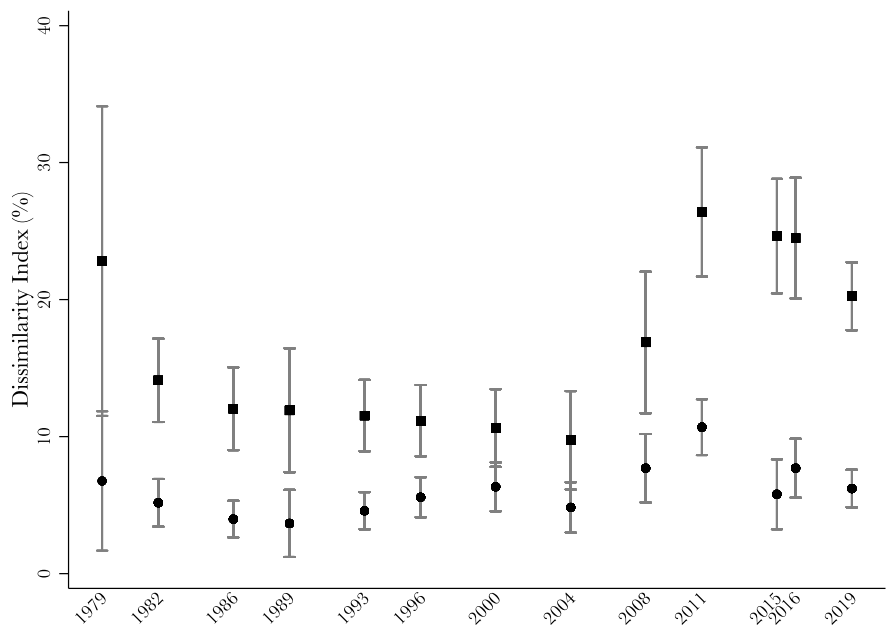


Figure 3. The evolution of the national average election dissimilarity scores from 1979 to 2023.



Note: 95% confidence intervals around the means. Squares display information on total dissimilarity, and circles capture dissimilarity between the left- and right-wing blocs.

¹ The last general elections were held in November 2019 and, thus, new elections were due again in the fall of 2023.

² According to the 1978 Spanish Constitution, political power at the subnational level is distributed among 17 autonomous communities and 2 autonomous cities (Ceuta and Melilla). This decentralized political system involves the configuration of a multilevel territorial structure whereby the goals and the strategies of most parties depend simultaneously on the national and regional arenas.

³ Constitutional Court's rulings 148/2021 and 183/2021: These rulings emphasised that the appropriate constitutional mechanism should have been the 'state of emergency'.

⁴ With a total of 20 meetings held between 2019 and 2023, summing up to 26 of its kind since 2004.

⁵ According to the 2023 May survey of the *Centro de Investigaciones Sociológicas* (Center for Sociological Research [CIS]).

⁶ Term coined by Pallarés, Montero and Llera (1997) to refer to parties whose principal point of reference of their identity, contrary to statewide parties, is the territorial (sub-national) sphere in which they carry out their activities and in relation to which they elaborate and project their political proposals.

⁷ Torra was found guilty of disobedience for delaying the removal of banners and yellow ribbons hung on public buildings in support of jailed pro-independence leaders during an election campaign in 2019.

⁸ Some months later Más Madrid entered the national arena by becoming Más País (More Country). Given this entry into the national arena, we prefer to avoid the term NSWP in this case.

⁹ We use June and December CIS barometers from 2019 to 2022. Specifically, we use the following datasets: 3252, 3269, 3283, 3303, 3326, 3344, 3366 and 3388.

¹⁰ As a response to a legal challenge against these lists, the Public Prosecutor's Office confirmed that the appealed candidacies were legal since they had fully served their sentences.

¹¹ It mentions the ETA member Francisco Javier García Gaztelu (nicknamed 'Txapote').

¹² On the one hand, PSOE and UPs reached agreements at the regional and local levels, in some places with the support of non-state-wide parties. On the other hand, the PP forged coalitions with Cs, sometimes with the parliamentary support of Vox after 2019.

¹³ According to the 5/1985 Organic Law, to become mayor a candidate needs a majority of votes in her favour in the local council, which practically entails that, usually, the most voted party in a municipality obtains the control of local government.

¹⁴ The PP was also the clear winner of the local elections that took place simultaneously in the whole country. Apart from obtaining almost 800,000 votes more than the Socialist Party, its candidates became mayors in 7 out of the 10 largest cities of the country.

¹⁵ Although founded as a regional party in 2006 in Catalonia, Cs made its jump to a state-wide party in the 2015 election cycle. Vox and Podemos were founded in December 2013 and January 2014 respectively, and, thus, the 2015 election cycle was also the first for them.

¹⁶ Some of these councillors left Cs and ran under new parties in 2023. For instance, Zamora Sí, created by the former President of Zamora's provincial government José Manuel Requejo, obtained 100 councillors in this province.

¹⁷ The so-called 'confluencias' (confluences) are political alliances between Podemos and other sub-national left-wing parties in some regions, such as in Galicia (Anova-En Marea), Catalonia (En Comú) and Valencia (Compromís), to maximize political representation.

¹⁸ Izquierda Unida is the electoral brand of the Communist Party of Spain since 1986. Equo is currently the most important Spanish green party, founded in 1986.

¹⁹ En Marea was a coalition created in Galicia by Anova, Podemos, Esquerda Unida, Equo Galicia, and Espazo Ecosocialista Galego to compete in 2016 regional and local elections. In 2020, En Común (Podemos, EU, Mareas En Común, and Equo) continued this alliance with Anova.

²⁰ Adelante Andalucía in 2018 was not the same as in 2022. In 2022, Izquierda Unida, Podemos, Más País, Equo, Iniciativa del Pueblo Andaluz, and Alianza Verde came together under the Por Andalucía label to electorally compete against Adelante Andalucía, which was refunded in 2022 to represent the anti-capitalist side of Andalusian radical left under the leadership of Teresa Rodríguez.

²¹ Following Russo, Riera and Verthé (2017), we do not consider a radical left party the Movimiento Cinque Stelle

²² Meloni's government (2022) in Italy, a 'right-to-far-right' coalition of Fratelli d'Italia, Lega, Forza Italia, and Noi Moderati, represents the only case in this regard.

²³ On the right, we consider PP, Ciudadanos, and Vox, UCD-CDS and UPyD. On the left, we consider PSOE, IU, Podemos or Unidas Podemos, and the territorial 'confluencias' depending on the election.

²⁴ If we apply Dalton (2008)'s Polarisation Index (PI) formula to the Manifesto Research on Political Representation (MARPOR) data for Spanish parties between 1979 and 2023, Spain's PI goes from below 1 to above 3 in 2019.